



▲ LIMESTONE STALACTITES AT VERCORS CAVES

Lascaux

Location Dordogne, southwest France

The walls of dozens of caves in the valley of the Vézère River, which flows through a limestone karst landscape, have ancient

illustrations painted or etched on them. Those in the cave at Lascaux, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, include a huge depiction of fighting aurochs (an extinct species of wild cattle) and are believed to be about 17,000 years old. The main cavern at Lascaux is 65 ft (20 m) wide and 16 ft (5 m) high.

The Rhône

Location From the Alps to the Mediterranean, Switzerland and southeast France

Meltwater from the Rhône Glacier (see p.359), high in the Swiss Alps, is the source of this river, which

flows for 505 miles (813 km) to the Mediterranean west of Marseilles. Its course follows large glaciated valleys to Lake Geneva, then southwest to Lyon, where it converges with its biggest tributary, the Saône. The Rhône changes direction to the south and flows between the Alps and the Massif Central before splitting into several branches of its delta at Arles.

Vercors Caves

Location Provence-Alpes region, southwest Alps, southeast France

This large limestone massif comprises a series of high plateaus divided by steep-sided valleys, including the Bourne and Furon gorges. Beneath the surface are many cave systems that quickly flood when the winter snow melts, or after heavy rain, and become treacherous. Highlights include the Grotte de Bournillon, which has an entrance 260 ft (80 m) high and 100 ft (30 m) wide—said to be the biggest in Europe. The Hall of the Thirteen, the main passage in the Gouffre Berger system, has massive stalagmites and delicate stalactites. Gouffre Berger was the first cave on Earth to be explored to a depth of more than 3,300 ft (1,000 m).

Grotte Casteret

Location The Pyrenees of Aragon, Spain

At an elevation of more than 8,500 ft (2,600 m), the limestone cave system at Grotte Casteret contains a huge chamber called Grande Salle. The subterranean hall, which is 230 ft (70 m) long and 200 ft (60 m) wide, has an extraordinary frozen floor of clear ice covering 22,000 square feet (2,000 square meters); the deeper layers of ice are believed to be very old. There are also spectacular ice columns and a 65-ft- (20-m-) high ice wall. The cavern was discovered in 1926.